still flourished. Besides, they also flag misuse of autonomy and an absence of accountability and commitment to performance—the slide on global rankings is cited as a case in point.

Key positions such as the chairperson and particularly the director hold immense power in an IIM. The chairperson leads the institute's board, which makes crucial decisions at the macro level. Two representatives from the state as well as the central governments, often IAS officers, occupy seats on these boards.

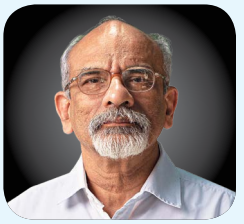
Previously, the director was appointed through a five-member committee, constituted and headed by the chairperson. The committee would shortlist three names and send them to the Union education ministry in an order of preference for approval. Now, the Visitor's nominee will be part of the selection process, raising concerns about increased government control. "There's nothing new about the government controlling appointments," says Prof. G. Raghuram, director of IIM Bangalore between 2017 and 2020. "One would be concerned about delays though.... I waited 10 months for a confirmation of my appointment." Raghuram was earlier the dean at IIM Ahmedabad (IIM-A).



**"THERE ARE CONCERNS ABOUT THE BIASES OF THE VISITOR, BUT WHAT ABOUT THE BIAS OF THE BOARD OR CHAIRMAN? AT LEAST THE VISITOR'S OFFICE IS PUBLICLY ACCOUNTABLE"**

**–PROF. BAKUL DHOLAKIA** *Former director, IIM Ahmedabad*

**"NOTHING IS NEW ABOUT THE GOVERNMENT CONTROLLING THE APPOINTMENTS. ONE WOULD BE CONCERNED ABOUT THE DELAYS THOUGH"**



**–PROF. G. RAGHURAM** *Former director, IIM Bangalore*

**THE VISITOR CAN APPOINT AND REMOVE THE CHAIRPERSON AND DIRECTOR, AND AUDIT IIM FUNCTIONING**

The issue that particularly bothers the critics of the new bill is that the Visitor has the power to remove the director and chairperson. The Visitor is being construed as the education ministry itself, as the President works on the advice of the council of ministers. "If the director and chairman are fearful of their job, it would make them toothless. Would they refuse to comply with a government directive that other stakeholders like the faculty members or the board disagree with?" asks a retired IIM-A faculty member. Earlier, the board appointed chairpersons, but now they will be appointed by the Visitor. "This effectively takes away all semblance of independence in the appointment process. Only the government's point of view will prevail in the appointment of both the key offices," says the retired professor.

Nayan Parikh, an IIM-A alumnus and a former member of its board, thinks the government's step was unnecessary. "There are two government representatives (among around 16 members) on the board of all IIMs. Any major decision taken by the board is invariably with total consensus. Even if the government nominees are in the minority, no board would like to pass any major decision without their consent on record," he explains.

The provision allowing the Visitor to conduct inquiries into IIM operations has emerged as contentious among faculty members who value the institutions as bastions of free thought and debate. They are concerned that "the hanging sword of an inquiry does not augur well for bold and out-of-the-box decisions required to stay ahead in a fast-changing competitive world of management education." But the government's assurance may put some of these concerns to rest. "I would like to assure Parliament that we don't have any intention of interfering with the academic autonomy of IIMs," education minister Dharmendra Pradhan said in defence of the new bill.

Raghuram agrees with the minister's view partially. "I don't fear significant interference in faculty recruitment or student admission, curriculum and academic rigour. The culture is strong on that and any attempt at interference will result in severe faculty pushback. The positive of this is a check mechanism for a rogue institution," he says, referring to an incident in IIM Rohtak, where the board controversially extended director Dheeraj Sharma's term despite a lack of academic credentials. Raghuram explains that the processes at IIMs are transparent and the director's office is a powerful backstop. But that is what appears to be the problem, highlighting a complex balance between autonomy and accountability.

For instance, in 2021, IIM-A refused to comply with BJP Rajya Sabha member Subramanian Swamy's demand to re-examine a thesis that referred to the BJP and BSP as 'ethnically formed parties', and termed the BJP as a 'pro-Hindu upper caste party'. Then director Errol D'Souza ignored the queries and requests